SPEAK TO TRAVEL

# The Brazilian Speaker's Error Guide

Companion to **File 1 (3-Month Program)**. These are the mistakes Portuguese speakers make most, with the fix and a quick drill for each. **Teacher tip:** don't teach this as a list. Use it to *recognize* errors during free talk, then pick the 3–5 that matter most for each student.

TEACHING MATERIAL

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# 01 Pronunciation — the "Big 8"

| # | Problem | What Brazilians do | Fix | Drill |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Extra "i" at the end** | *big-i, like-i, Facebook-i, hot-dog-i* | Stop the sound. Close the mouth / hold the tongue. | *big, book, like, stop, good, work, nice, Brazil* |
| 2 | **TH** | *"tank you", "fank you", "sree"* | Tongue lightly between the teeth, blow air | *think, three, thank, Thursday, third, mouth · the, this, that, mother* |
| 3 | **Initial R / H** | *rice → "hice"; hotel → "rotel"* (with Portuguese R) | English R: tongue curled back, doesn't touch anything. English H: just soft air | *red/head, rice, right, Rio · house, hotel, happy, help* |
| 4 | **Final -ED** | *work-ed, play-ed, ask-ed* | 3 sounds: /t/ worked · /d/ played · /id/ only after t/d: wanted, needed | *I asked, I liked, I stopped · I called, I stayed · I visited, I waited* |
| 5 | **Vowel length** | *ship = sheep, live = leave, full = fool* | Long vowels are LONG and tense; short ones relaxed | *sit/seat, live/leave, fill/feel, pull/pool · beach, sheet, piece* (keep long!) |
| 6 | **Final M / N** | *"time"* sounds like *"taym", "I'm"* like *"aim"* nasal | Close the lips for M, touch tongue on top for N | *time, name, home, come · ten, fine, phone, train* |
| 7 | **Initial S + consonant** | *"es-tudent", "es-pain", "es-tarbucks"* | Start directly with S — no "e" before | *student, Spain, Starbucks, school, stop, speak, small* |
| 8 | **Final L** | *"Brazil" → "Braziu", "hotel" → "hoteu"* | Tongue touches behind the top teeth at the end | *Brazil, hotel, call, feel, people, little* |

**Also:** word stress (*HO-tel* × → *ho-TEL*; *de-VE-lop*; *COM-for-ta-ble* = "COMF-ter-bul"); "I" sound in English is often "ai" (*idea = ai-DI-a*), and many silent letters (*walk, talk, half, Wednesday, listen, island*).

# 02 False friends (falsos cognatos) — the dangerous ones

| English word | Means | NOT | Portuguese meaning → English |
|---|---|---|---|
| **actually** | na verdade | atualmente | → *currently / nowadays* |
| **eventually** | finalmente, com o tempo | eventualmente | → *occasionally* |
| **pretend** | fingir | pretender | → *intend / plan* |
| **push** | empurrar | puxar | → *pull* |

| English word | Means | NOT | Portuguese meaning → English |
|---|---|---|---|
| **parents** | pai e mãe | parentes | → *relatives* |
| **library** | biblioteca | livraria | → *bookstore* |
| **lunch** | almoço | lanche | → *snack* |
| **exquisite** | requintado, refinado | esquisito | → *weird / strange* |
| **college** | faculdade | colégio | → *(high) school* |
| **attend** | frequentar, comparecer | atender | → *answer (phone) / serve (customer)* |
| **assist** | ajudar | assistir | → *watch* |
| **realize** | perceber | realizar | → *achieve / accomplish* |
| **sensible** | sensato | sensível | → *sensitive* |
| **constipated** | com intestino preso | constipado (resfriado) | → *have a cold / congested* |
| **injury** | ferimento | injúria | → *insult* |
| **novel** | romance (livro) | novela | → *soap opera* |
| **fabric** | tecido | fábrica | → *factory* |
| **legend** | lenda / legenda de mapa | legenda (de filme) | → *subtitles* |
| **costume** | fantasia | costume | → *habit / custom* |
| **prejudice** | preconceito | prejuízo | → *loss / damage* |
| **support** | apoiar | suportar | → *stand / tolerate* |
| **lecture** | palestra | leitura | → *reading* |
| **resume** (verb) | retomar | resumir | → *summarize* |
| **comprehensive** | abrangente, completo | compreensivo | → *understanding* |
| **intend** | ter intenção | entender | → *understand* |
| **exit** | saída | êxito | → *success* |

## 03 "Translated" sentences — the grammar traps

| ❌ Brazilian translation | ✅ Natural English | Note |
|---|---|---|
| I have 60 years. | **I'm 60.** / I'm 60 years old. | Age uses BE |
| I am agree. | **I agree.** | Agree is a verb |

| ❌ Brazilian translation | ✅ Natural English | Note |
|---|---|---|
| I'm with hunger / cold / headache. | **I'm hungry / cold. I have a headache.** | |
| Do you want that I help you? | **Do you want me to help you?** | |
| She said me… | **She told me… / She said (that)…** | tell + person |
| I lost the bus / the flight. | **I missed the bus / my flight.** | |
| I'm going to make a question. | **I'd like to ask a question.** | ask a question |
| I made a party / a trip. | **I had a party. I took a trip.** | |
| People is nice. | **People are nice.** | People = plural |
| I live here since 2010. | **I've lived here since 2010.** | Teach as chunk |
| It depends of… | **It depends on…** | |
| I'm thinking in going. | **I'm thinking about going.** | |
| Explain me… | **Explain to me… / Can you explain…?** | |
| I need go. / I want go. | **I need to go. / I want to go.** | |
| He don't like… | **He doesn't like…** | 3rd person |
| Is very beautiful. | **It's very beautiful.** | English needs a subject |
| Have many people here. | **There are a lot of people here.** | "Tem" = there is/are |
| I stayed in the house. | **I stayed home / at home.** | |
| Do you like to have a coffee? | **Would you like a coffee?** | invitation |
| How do you call this? | **What do you call this?** / How do you say…? | |
| I'm boring. | **I'm bored.** | "boring" = chato (causes) |
| What means ___? | **What does ___ mean?** | question order |
| Where is the bathroom? (US) | **Where's the restroom?** | works, but restroom is more natural in public places |
| I want a beer. | **Could I get a beer, please?** | "I want" can sound rude |

# 04 Conversation habits (cultural)

- **Too direct requests** ("Give me…", "I want…") → soften with *Could I…? / Can I get…? / I'd like…*. In English, politeness lives in the grammar.
- **Too long answers to officials** → in immigration and interviews, short and direct. Brazilians tend to explain too much when nervous.
- **Not saying "please", "thank you", "sorry", "excuse me"** often enough — English speakers use them constantly.
- **Interrupting / speaking at the same time** — normal in Brazil, can seem rude in the US/UK. Practice waiting for the end of the sentence.
- **Physical closeness / touching** — in many English-speaking countries, people keep more distance with strangers.
- **"Yes" when you didn't understand** — the most dangerous habit. Always: *"Sorry, could you repeat that?"*